he maintains, has only the country's progress in mind.

That's the reason the Congress, which is acting as the fulcrum of Opposition unity, did its homework, for once, before the two-day gathering—the second such meeting in less than a month after the first one in Patna on June 23. Wisening up to the BJP, the Congress came up with the proposal to call their alliance INDIA. Modi has consistently used smart acronyms to drive home his message to the masses. The Grand Old Party, which has now enlisted professional campaign managers, has taken a leaf out of that playbook to come up with a coinage that Modi and the BJP may find difficult to ridicule.

The move is of a piece with what Rahul Gandhi indicated during his Bharat Jodo Yatra—to pitch the 2024 election as a battle between the idea of India and Modi's BJP. In Bengaluru, he said, "The battle is for the idea of India. That is why we came up with this name. The battle is between the NDA and INDIA, their ideology and INDIA. And you know who wins when somebody stands against India."

The Opposition alliance is clearly in no mood to yield an inch in this game of perception-building. When Assam chief minister and BJP leader Himanta Biswa Sarma pooh-poohed the nomenclature saying that India is a name the British gave the country and that our forefathers fought for the independence of Bharat, Team INDIA promptly added the tagline 'Jeetega Bharat' to blunt the attack. At the same time, the alliance realises the battle must go beyond mere wordplay. The 'samuhik sankalp' (common pledge) that was released after the Bengaluru conclave vowed "to present to the nation an alternative political, social and economic agenda". So, if the BJP is raising the tempo on the Uniform Civil Code in the penultimate year before the election in an attempt at communal polarisation (since the measure is perceived to be directed against a specific minority community), INDIA has promised a caste census in the hope that voting along caste lines will prevent any consolidation of the Hindu vote.

The effort to project INDIA shining was all too visible. The Congress may have coined the acronym, but Rahul insisted that Mamata propose it. In response, she called him "our favourite", a sharp departure from her previous criticism of his leadership. Surrounding that was an even more significant signal from Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge: that the party was not hankering after the PM's post. That came as a relief to several partners, who had in private expressed doubts about Rahul being the face of the alliance. They believe that in any national duel, the Congress scion lags far behind Modi in the public perception. The Congress also won over Delhi CM and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) leader Arvind Kejriwal by opposing the controversial central ordinance denying the Delhi government a final say in the transfer and postings of bureaucrats in the national capital. By doing so, the Congress high command went against its Delhi unit, which is opposed to the AAP. Returning the favour, Kejriwal instructed his party members to rein in their punches against the Congress.

THE CONGRES MADE A SIGNIFICANT CONCESSION, SAYING IT WAS NOT HANKERING FOR THE PM'S POST

AND YET...

Even after two meetings, there has been no word on a seat-sharing formula. And it's unlikely that any consensus will be built in the next meeting, scheduled for mid-August in Mumbai. The non-Congress parties want the national party to focus on areas where it is in direct combat with the BJP and play the junior partner in states like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Punjab and Delhi.

This may run counter to what the Congress units in these states might want, but the fact remains that INDIA will have the maximum electoral impact in these seven states that account for 244 of the 543 Lok Sabha seats. In Bihar and Jharkhand, the Congress is a part of alliances already entrenched in power. In Maharashtra, BJP machinations have eroded the electoral capital of the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi alliance of the Sena, the NCP and the Congress by splitting the first two formations. With both the Uddhav Thackeray-led Sena faction as well as that of the Sharad Pawar-led NCP likely to be diminished, the Congress just may demand a large share of the pie.

However, it's West Bengal, Delhi and Punjab that may see the toughest seat-sharing bargain. Though the Congress has joined hands with the Left in Bengal, despite both sides being bitterly opposed in Kerala, will Mamata and the Left agree to a pre-poll seat-sharing formula? On July 17, a day before he sat at the same dining table as Mamata, CPI(M) leader Sitaram Yechury ruled out any alliance with the TMC in West Bengal, saying secular parties along with the Left and the Congress will take on the BJP as well as the TMC in the state. Even the state Congress is hostile to the TMC. "Why should we give a walkover to the TMC in West Bengal?" asks a Congress MP from the state. "In the name of defeating the BJP, we cannot compromise our own existence. The alliance should add value to both sides."

Similarly, the Delhi and Punjab units of the Congress are unwilling to board the same bus as the AAP. It is the latter and not the BJP that poses an existential threat to the Congress in both states. In fact, Rashtriya Janata Dal patriarch Lalu Prasad had to chide Punjab CM and AAP leader Bhagwant Mann for attacking the Congress just before the Bengaluru meet. Despite these frictions, the Opposition camp is hopeful of finding a mutually acceptable poll formula. "This is the beginning," says an RJD leader. "What you saw in Bengaluru was unimaginable even six months ago. Keep watching